# Anaphors always have nominative forms

Gleb Bubnov[1]
ke.pupo2004@gmail.com

**The problem.** In many languages, anaphors cannot appear in positions that require nominative case, even though the binding conditions are satisfied, cf. (1).

(1) Icelandic (Rizzi 1990: ex. 17)

a. Jón segir að María elski sig.
John says that Maria loves.SBJV REFL
'John$_i$ says that Maria loves him$_i$.'

b. * Jón segir að sig elski María.
John says that REFL loves.SBJV Maria
Intended: 'John$_i$ says that he$_i$ loves Maria.'

Rizzi (1990) attributes this to the Anaphor Agreement Effect (AAE): anaphors cannot trigger agreement. The AAE has since been repeatedly weakened to accommodate anaphoric (Woolford 1999), $\phi$-invariant (Tucker 2012) and indirect agreement (Sundaresan 2016). However, full $\phi$-covarying agreement with anaphors was argued to be attested in Tamil (Murugesan 2019), Avar (Rudnev 2020), and some other languages, so the AAE cannot be a universal principle. The Encapsulation Hypothesis (Preminger 2019, Rudnev 2020) derives the variation in agreement and dispenses with the AAE. Rudnev (2022) eliminates a domain-specific principle altogether: trivial agreement follows from the nominal nature of anaphors, and the ban reflects a historically idiosyncratic gap in the paradigm – the nominative form is missing (cf. Maling 1984).

This leaves two problems. First, a paradigm gap is a stipulation, and it remains unexplained why exactly this gap is so widespread. Second, where the anaphor is blocked, the result is not ungrammaticality: a pronominal surfaces instead, in a configuration from which the binding conditions should exclude it. In Icelandic, a dative subject requires a clause-bound reflexive (2a), yet a nominative object bound by the same kind of subject is a pronominal (2b).

(2) Icelandic (Maling 1984: ex. 7)

a. Honum$_i$ er oft kalt heima hjá sér$_i$ / *honum$_i$.
him.DAT is often cold home at REFL.DAT / him.DAT
'He$_i$ is often cold at his$_i$ own place.'

b. Henni$_i$ finnst hún$_i$ veik.
her.DAT finds she.NOM sick
'She$_i$ considers herself$_i$ sick.'

Any account of the AAE thus owes an explanation not only of the case/agreement restriction, but also of this switch in the form of the bound expression. Standardly, it is delegated to a competition rule preferring reflexives over pronominals (Reinhart 1983, Burzio 1991, Hornstein 2001, Reuland 2011, Johnson 2026).

**Proposal.** I go further and argue that accusative "anaphors" and nominative "pronominals" bound in the same way are one and the same element. Anaphors **always have** nominative forms (and can in principle agree), but in the languages at hand the nominative anaphor is **syncretic** with the nominative pronominal. *Hún* in (2b) is thus the nominative reflexive, and the complementary distribution of "anaphors" and "pronominals" follows from case, without a gap and without a competition rule. Syncretism is independently needed in every inflectional domain, so this is the more parsimonious option. Where the nominative anaphor is not syncretic, it surfaces overtly, as in mentioned above Tamil and Avar.

**Syncretisms.** Pronominal–anaphor syncretism is attested elsewhere in the paradigm and outside the nominative, see (3). In Frisian, the accusative weak feminine singular anaphor *har* is syncretic with the corresponding accusative pronominal (Hoekstra & Vanden Wyngaerd 2023); on the present view, the

[1]This work is an output of a research project HSE-BR-2025-032 implemented as part of the Basic Research Program at HSE University.

nominative cell, standardly taken to be empty, is filled by the equally syncretic *sy*. In English, predicative possessors are never "reflexive" (Johnson 2026): in *Julie$_i$ likes pictures of {herself$_i$ / ??her$_i$}* vs. *Julie$_i$ likes pictures of {hers$_i$ / *herself's}* the bound position is the same, but the object form is an anaphor and the predicative possessive form is a "pronominal". I treat *hers* as the predicative possessive form of both paradigms. The effect therefore has nothing to do with agreement at all.

(3) Syncretic cells (shaded alike)

Icelandic, 3SG.F

| | PRON | REFL |
|---|---|---|
| NOM | **hún** | **hún** |
| ACC | hana | sig |
| DAT | henni | sér |

Frisian, 3SG.F

| | PRON | REFL |
|---|---|---|
| NOM | **sy** | **sy** |
| ACC | **har** | **har** |

English, 3SG.F

| | PRON | REFL |
|---|---|---|
| OBJ | her | her-self |
| PRED.POSS | **her-s** | **her-s** |

**Support from the movement theory of binding.** On the view that anaphors are lower copies of their antecedents (Lidz & Idsardi 1998, Hornstein 2001, 2007, Drummond 2011), the proposal makes a testable prediction: overtly realized lower copies should also show an anaphor in the accusative and a "pronominal" in the nominative.[2] This is exactly what pronoun copying shows (Van Urk 2018). In Wambeek Dutch, the nominative lower copy of a moved subject is spelled out as the "pronominal" *zij* (4a), whereas the accusative lower copy of a bound object is the anaphor *zich* (4b).

(4) a. Wambeek Dutch (Van Craenenbroeck & Van Koppen 2002: p. 56)
**Dei vrou**$_i$ gui **zij**$_i$.
that woman goes she
'That woman is going.'

b. Dutch (Rooryck 2011: p. 105)
**Josée**$_i$ heeft **zich**$_i$ gewassen.
Josée has REFL washed
'Josée washed herself.'

The same complementary distribution by case as in (2) thus arises in movement chains. Contra Lidz & Idsardi (1998), what matters for the spell-out of the lower copy is not the number of $\theta$-roles or cases in the chain – a (non-anaphoric) DP may receive case more than once (Bejar & Massam 1999) and bear several $\theta$-roles (Ramchand 2008) – but the case of the lower copy itself.

**Conclusion.** There is no dedicated Anaphor Agreement Effect and no paradigm gap: anaphors always have nominative forms, often syncretic with pronominals. This eliminates both the AAE and the competition rule for the nominative, and predicts that in languages with distinct nominative anaphors and pronoun copying, nominative pronoun copies should be anaphors.

## References


Bejar, Susana & Diane Massam. 1999. Multiple Case Checking. en. *Syntax* 2(2). 65–79. https://doi.org/10.1111/1467-9612.00015.

Bruening, Benjamin. 2021. Generalizing the Presuppositional Approach to the Binding Conditions. en. *Syntax* 24(4). 417–461. https://doi.org/10.1111/synt.12221.

Burzio, Luigi. 1991. The morphological basis of anaphora. en. *Journal of Linguistics* 27(1). 81–105. https://doi.org/10.1017/S0022226700012421.

Drummond, Alex. 2011. *Binding phenomena within a reductionist theory of grammatical dependencies*. University of Maryland, College Park. (8 June, 2026).

Hoekstra, Eric & Guido Vanden Wyngaerd. 2023. Reflexives in Dutch and Frisian. In *The handbook on the syntax of the Germanic languages*. To appear. LingBuzz 007551.

Hornstein, Norbert. 2001. *Move! a minimalist theory of construal*. eng. 1. publ (Generative syntax 5). Malden, Mass.: Blackwell.

Hornstein, Norbert. 2007. Pronouns in a Minimalist Setting. en. In Norbert Corver & Jairo Nunes (eds.), *Linguistik Aktuell/Linguistics Today*, vol. 107, 351–385. Amsterdam: John Benjamins Publishing Company. https://doi.org/10.1075/la.107.15hor.


[2] I restrict the claim to anaphors that behave as lower copies, e.g. resist coordination (cf. Bruening 2021); the classification of anaphors is set aside here.

Johnson, Kyle. 2026. Getting B to follow A. Talk given at the University of Vienna.
Lidz, Jeffrey & William J. Idsardi. 1998. Chains and phono-logical form. *U. Penn Working Papers in Linguistics* 5(1). 109–125. (7 June, 2026).
Maling, Joan. 1984. Non-clause-bounded reflexives in modern Icelandic. en. *Linguistics and Philosophy* 7(3). 211–241. https://doi.org/10.1007/BF00627706.
Murugesan, Gurujegan. 2019. *Predicting the Anaphor Agreement Effect and its violations* PhD Thesis.
Preminger, Omer. 2019. The Anaphor Agreement Effect: further evidence against binding-as-agreement. Unpublished ms., University of Maryland at College Park. Version v7. https://ling.auf.net/lingbuzz/004401.
Ramchand, Gillian. 2008. *Verb meaning and the lexicon: a first-phase syntax* (Cambridge studies in linguistics 116). Cambridge, UK ; New York: Cambridge University Press.
Reinhart, Tanya. 1983. Coreference and bound anaphora: A restatement of the anaphora questions. *Linguistics and Philosophy* 6(1). 47–88. http://www.jstor.org/stable/25001118.
Reuland, Eric. 2011. *Anaphora and language design*. eng (Linguistic inquiry monographs 62). Cambridge (Mass.): MIT press.
Rizzi, Luigi. 1990. On the anaphor agreement effect. *Rivista di Grammatica Generativa* 2. 27. (20 June, 2026).
Rooryck, Johan. 2011. *Dissolving Binding Theory*. eng (Oxford Studies in Theoretical Linguistics,32). Oxford: Oxford University Press.
Rudnev, Pavel. 2020. The Anaphor Agreement Effect is not about featural deficiency: Evidence from Avar. *Glossa: a journal of general linguistics* 5(1). https://doi.org/10.5334/gjgl.907.
Rudnev, Pavel. 2022. The Anaphor Agreement Effect as epiphenomenon. In *The many facets of agreement*. https://pavelrudnev.github.io/papers/rudnev-agreement-chapter-standalone.pdf (20 June, 2026).
Sundaresan, Sandhya. 2016. Anaphora vs. agreement: A new kind of Anaphor Agreement Effect in Tamil. In Patrick Grosz & Pritty Patel-Grosz (eds.), *The Impact of Pronominal Form on Interpretation*, 77–106. De Gruyter. https://doi.org/10.1515/9781614517016-004.
Tucker, Matthew. 2012. On the derivation of the Anaphor Agreement Effect. Unpublished ms., UC Santa Cruz.
Van Craenenbroeck, Jeroen & Marjo Van Koppen. 2002. Subject doubling in Dutch dialects. In *Proceedings of Console IX*, 54–67. University of Leiden Leiden. (27 May, 2026).
Van Urk, Coppe. 2018. Pronoun copying in Dinka Bor and the Copy Theory of Movement. en. *Natural Language & Linguistic Theory* 36(3). 937–990. https://doi.org/10.1007/s11049-017-9384-x.
Woolford, Ellen. 1999. More on the Anaphor Agreement Effect. en. *Linguistic Inquiry* 30(2). 257–287. https://doi.org/10.1162/002438999554057.